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EDITORIAL

BRYDIE-LEIGH BARTLEET

Griffith University

DON COFFMAN

University of Miami

ROGER MANTIE

University of Toronto Scarborough

The ethics of being an editor–researcher

ABSTRACT

Although only a few months old at press time, ChatGPT has already established itself as one of the biggest disruptors of historical conceptions of authorship, reality and trust. The research community will no doubt face increasing challenges as it attempts to deal with peer review, conflicts-of-interest and publishing ethics. Readers may know that the International Journal of Community Music is a Committee on Publication Ethics (COPE) member. COPE establishes ethical guidelines for the academic publishing. No doubt these will evolve in the face of emerging artificial intelligence technology. The existing guidelines are helpful but still leave many issues unaddressed, such as what researchers should do when it comes to publishing in a journal they edit. In addition to Kathleen Turner's autoethnographic reflective essay about the challenges arising from the COVID-19 crisis on a university-based community music training programme and Anna McMichael's study of composer/musicians involved with the annual classical

KEYWORDS

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1. By science we do not mean just the natural sciences, but all scholarly based research and inquiry.

Tyalgum Music Festival in regional Australia, Issue 16:1 features three articles authored or co-authored by the journal's editors, who devised an in-house system to ensure the integrity of the double-blind peer review system. The issue concludes with a dedication to Janice Waldron (1957–2022), who passed away suddenly and unexpectedly in November 2022.

INTRODUCTION

And just like that, ChatGPT changed the 'rules' of countless fields – some of which, like education, have relied on basic assumptions about reality for hundreds if not thousands of years. Plato is probably the most well-known western thinker to have brought concerns about reality to the fore. In the article, 'Plato and the simulacrum', Gilles Deleuze and Rosalind Krauss summarize several aspects of Plato's thought: 'to distinguish essence from appearance, the intelligible from the sensible, the Idea from the image, the original from the copy, the model from the simulacrum' (1983: 47). The thing about ChatGPT is that it threatens one of the most fundamental building blocks of human reality: *trust*. (Was this editorial really written by the editors or did they have AI write it?)

When we remove trust, we remove our ability to navigate the world. One of the things that made the US presidency of Donald Trump so damaging is that he removed any pretence of truth. When one of the most important elected public officials in the world is willing to consistently and deliberately lie and cast doubt on science, it erodes not just the public's faith in science-based reality, but any and all claims to reality itself.¹ The message is clear: we cannot trust experts; everyone can believe whatever they want to believe. All opinions are equal.

The issue of trust lies at the heart of scholarly activity. As scholars and researchers, we are entrusted with pursuing the 'truth' – a truth that may be partial, perspectival and political – but a kind of truth that is distinguished from lies and deception. The practice that underlies this trust is peer review. While far from perfect (see Kelly et al. 2014), peer review – and especially blind (and double-blind) peer review – remains the basis for attempting to ensure that readers can trust what is published. In principle, this is relatively easy: authors submit manuscripts devoid of self-identifying material, editors assign peer reviewers with appropriate expertise to properly assess and evaluate the manuscripts, the reviewers return their judgements along with recommendations and the manuscripts deemed worthy of publication see the light of day in academic journals. In practice, it is a lot more complicated. All manner of potential conflicts of interest might compromise the process. For example, what if the research is funded by an organization (or company)? What if the author is affiliated in some way with an organization or company? Would such knowledge affect the judgements of the peer reviewers and editors? What are the policies and practices for disclosing and reporting such conflicts of interest? The number of ethical issues can go on (and on).

The Committee on Publication Ethics (COPE) is a non-profit organization founded in 1997 that currently has over 12,000 member journals. It establishes basic guidelines for ethical conduct in academic journal publishing. As a journal published by Intellect, *International Journal of Community Music (IJCM)* is a COPE member. Intellect's ethical guidelines statement is linked on the *IJCM* website (<https://www.intellectbooks.com/ethical-guidelines>).

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Although helpful and seemingly rigorous, the guidelines still leave many issues unaddressed. What should an editor do to disclose a conflict of interest when published articles are closely related to their own interests, for example? Or more specifically as concerns the articles published in this issue: what are editors supposed to do when their own research activities are in community music and there is only one high-profile scholarly journal for community music? Should we, as editors, suspend our research during the term of our editorship? Would that not be a form of career punishment over and above the amount of service hours already dedicated to editing the journal? If we do choose to publish in *IJCM*, how can readers trust that the editors aren't flaunting the rules to advance their own careers?

Peer review for editor–authors

Given the rapid growth and development of community music across the world, as editors we have been cognizant of the vital role this journal can play in capturing, communicating and shaping the advancement of practice and research in our field. This has prompted recent dialogues between us and our editorial board about how we define this dynamic field of ours, and how we can open up spaces for new approaches, lines of enquiry, cultural contexts, voices and concerns to find a place within in our journal. This collective editorial thinking has also been informed by our own individual research endeavours in community music practice and research. As editors, we all came to realize we were keen to share our current thoughts and research projects with the broader field, and our journal was the ideal place to situate them.

This process of publishing in the journal we edit has raised broader questions to which many editors will relate. As editors of field-defining journals we are naturally engaged in our fields as researchers. We have many projects of relevance and thoughts about key issues in our field. Yet, there seems to be an unspoken rule that it is not appropriate to share our own work in the journals we edit, the implication being that this is unethical. We should rather make space for, support and curate the voices of others in our field without inserting our own in dialogue with them. However, we have come to wonder about the ethics of keeping our voices silent in this space. Our sense is that a more ethical approach might be to be open and make space for our readers to hear where our current thinking and research are at.

This decision raised practical concerns for us, as we were keen to ensure that the peer review of our work adhered to the highest principles of integrity and rigour. We developed a protocol that entailed the allocation of blind reviewers outside our regular editorial board and online reviewing platform to strictly ensure anonymity. We editors reviewed each other's manuscripts to ensure the greatest rigour possible. We also waited for an issue of the journal where we knew there would be space, instead of bumping other articles off the bill, so to speak.

Our respective articles all offer different, yet complementary takes on current thought in our field, from concerns of interdisciplinarity, to the contribution our journal has made to discourse in the field over many years, to frameworks for understanding and articulating the social impact of community music. We hope that these articles, in combination with the other contributions, will open the conversations we have been having as editors to a wider audience and play a role in continuing to shape our rapidly expanding field worldwide.

In this issue

This issue of *IJCM* begins with contributions from the editors. Don and Nicolas Coffman examined the contents of 45 issues of *IJCM* from inception, noting that nearly half of the issues have been special-themed issues. Their analysis suggests that the journal has evolved, increasing in the proportion of research articles and essays that critique the field. Authorship has been overwhelmingly from English-speaking countries in North America, Europe and Australia/New Zealand. The authors use their findings to discuss 'what should the journal include?'

Brydie-Leigh Bartleet proposes a conceptual framework for understanding and conveying the social impact of community music efforts. Her framework acknowledges that outcomes can range from the individual to the macro level, as well as the immediate to long-term effects. And outcomes can range from maintaining stasis to fostering significant change. Her framework helps practitioners and researchers think more critically and communicate more accurately about the impacts we sometimes take for granted.

Lloyd McArton and Roger Mantie examined the discussion of health and well-being-related terms and concepts (*health, well-being, quality of life, wellness*) in *IJCM* articles, with a view towards considering the implications of the use of such terms for the practice and research of community music. An integrative review methodology was used to determine the degree of conceptual coherence on health and well-being related terms, revealing a lack of coherence, no doubt because the terms are rarely operationalized in *IJCM* articles. They observed that, 'findings from studies are not comparable and it is difficult for the knowledge base to advance'.

Kathleen Turner contributes an autoethnographic reflective essay about the challenges arising from the COVID-19 crisis on a university-based community music training programme. Extracts from her professional teaching journal are used to explore early feelings of loss and grief, followed by increasing understanding of the possibilities, and some uncomfortable truths, that COVID-19 caused her to consider. She remarks,

The pandemic has demonstrated very clearly that we are not 'all in this together', as people have been disproportionately disadvantaged and harmed along gender, race, disability and geographical lines. This is in sharp contrast to the compassionate work that community music calls for.
(91 in this issue)

Anna McMichael interviewed six composer/musicians 'who had devised works of experimental music that involved community participants over six years at the annual classical Tyalgum Music Festival in regional Australia'. These musicians reflected on the enjoyable and valuable processes of co-creation and performance with individuals who might be viewed as simply an audience. Their comments resonate with Bartleet's framework for considering the social outcomes of community music. McMichael's reflections have implications for mainstream arts, cultural practices and festival curation.

We conclude with a dedication to Janice Waldron (1957–2022), who passed away suddenly and unexpectedly in November 2022. Waldron was well-known in community music circles as a regular attendee at the Community Music Activity commission of the International Society for Music Education. At the forefront of using media theory to inform community music practices,

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her landmark research into the connections between online and offline musical communities will no doubt continue to influence community music scholarship for decades to come. Kari Veblen, Jonathan Bayley, Kirsten Allstaff, Danielle Sirek and Roger Mantie offer personalized reflections on her life and work and the legacy she has left for scholars and practitioners of community music.

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CONTRIBUTOR DETAILS

Brydie-Leigh Bartleet is professor and Australian Research Council future fellow at the Creative Arts Research Institute and Queensland Conservatorium Griffith University.

Contact: Griffith University, South Bank Campus, P.O. Box 3428, Queensland 4101, Australia.

E-mail: b.bartleet@griffith.edu.au

 <https://orcid.org/0000-0003-4346-780X>

Don Coffman is professor of music education and chairs the Department of Music Education and Music Therapy at the Frost School of Music.

Contact: Frost School of Music, University of Miami, 5549 San Amaro Drive, Coral Gables, FL 33146, USA.

E-mail: d.coffman1@miami.edu

 <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-6655-4626>

Roger Mantie is professor, Department of Arts, Culture and Media at University of Toronto Scarborough, with a graduate appointment at the Ontario Institute for Studies in Education.

Contact: University of Toronto Scarborough, 1265 Military Trail, Scarborough, ON M1C 1A4, Canada.

E-mail: roger.mantie@utoronto.ca

 <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-5150-3279>

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